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FRAMING FALSE INFORMATION

Examining Legislators' Discourse Surrounding January 6

Christina P. Walker

The proliferation of false information poses a threat to democratic processes as it undermines trust in institutions and exacerbates polarization (Allcott & Gentzkow, 2017; Edelman, 2001; Marchetti, 2020). While considerable research has examined the impact of false political information on voter behavior and public opinion (Berinsky, 2017; Nyhan & Reifler, 2010; Weeks & Garrett, 2014), less attention has been paid to understanding how politicians themselves produce and disseminate such information. Knowing how politicians discuss and frame false information—encompassing both accidental misinformation and intentional disinformation—could offer insights into the mechanisms behind their dissemination and its strategic use in shaping public discourse, influencing political agendas, and manipulating public opinion. Therefore, I ask: How do politicians discuss false information?

This inquiry into how politicians talk about false information holds significant importance for researchers interested in the dynamics of political communication. While existing literature acknowledges the escalating prevalence of false information in contemporary discourse, a notable dearth remains in exploring the motivations that propel political elites to disseminate false information (Allcott & Gentzkow, 2017). This study focuses on the specific context of the 2021 U.S. Capitol insurrection. It aims to unravel the discourse strategies political elites employ in discussing and framing false information and the potential motivations underlying the dissemination. Through a computational text analysis of data extracted from the public hearings of the United States House Select Committee on the January 6 attack, I conduct a thematic analysis to discern blame attribution for the event. The outcomes of this investigation hold the potential to understand

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the shaping of political and discursive agendas. A nuanced understanding of elite framing of false information could facilitate more targeted efforts to counter false information and strengthen democratic processes, contributing to the ongoing discourse on the impact of false information in politics.

I capture how politicians discuss false information by analyzing the January 6 Committee hearings through transcripts made from C-SPAN recordings. By understanding the topics raised across the hearings, I discern the specific issues and concerns surrounding false information articulated by politicians. Examining the sentiment conveyed through the language employed provides insights into legislators' emotional tone and rhetorical strategies. Additionally, exploring the most frequently used words unveils the focal points in the discourse. This multifaceted approach to linguistic analysis provides a comprehensive understanding of the politicians' discourse surrounding false information, serving as a foundation for interpreting the motivations and broader implications of political communication in the context of the January 6 Committee hearings. The findings suggest that the more neutral and sometimes positive tones within the hearings could have limited their impact on public opinion and the broader understanding of the depth of the issue of false information.

FALSE INFORMATION IN POLITICS

The literature on false information underscores its negative impact on democracy, emphasizing the changing media landscape and the rise of social media as pivotal factors (Allcott & Gentzkow, 2017; Edelman, 2001; Marchetti, 2020). Scholars initially anticipated social media to fortify democratic norms, yet it has, paradoxically, facilitated the dissemination of false information, altering political campaigns and eroding democratic values (Diamond & Plattner, 2012; Persily, 2017; Rackaway, 2023; Tucker et al., 2018). The literature primarily focuses on the spread of false information among citizens, exploring echo chambers and mitigation strategies while neglecting the motivations behind political elites' dissemination of false information (Epstein et al., 2020; Nelimarkka et al., 2018). Consequently, gaps persist in understanding why politicians share false information.

The existing research explores citizen motivations for sharing false information, encompassing unintentional sharing models based on cognitive limitations and intentional sharing models rooted in psychological and material benefits

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(Osmundsen et al., 2021; Talwar et al., 2019; Temming, 2018). For example, there remain debates on the influence of reputation costs (Effron & Raj, 2020; Gao et al., 2018; Sunstein, 2018). Likewise, partisan benefits in sharing false information remain unclear. Scholars highlight the role of affective polarization, ideological preferences, and party identity in shaping these motivations (Bennett & Livingston, 2018; Flynn & Krupnikov, 2019). The interplay between political misperceptions, polarization, and false information underscores the importance of examining the sender side of the causal chain.

However, politicians' role in spreading false information remains an underexplored dimension (Acemoglu et al., 2021; Tucker, 2023). While it is acknowledged that politicians share false information, scant attention has been paid to understanding the underlying motivations driving this behavior (Mosleh & Rand, 2022; Weeks & Gil de Zúñiga, 2021). I address this by focusing on elite discourse, utilizing computational text analysis of the January 6 Committee hearings transcripts to unveil how politicians discuss false information.

FRAMING FALSE INFORMATION

The framing literature provides a valuable framework for understanding how political elites shape and present information to the public, which is crucial in the context of false information and its impact on democracy. Framing can help in understanding political communication and the construction of political narratives (Matthes, 2012) as it offers insights into the strategic choices made by political actors in shaping public discourse and influencing public opinion via agenda-setting (Walgrave et al., 2018). While studies have applied framing theory to analyze political discourse and communication strategies in various contexts (Holbert et al., 2005; Roman et al., 2022), there is a need to extend it to encompass elite discourse, particularly in the context of political hearings and committee proceedings.

How elites frame false information and why it matters coincides with elite cue theory. This theory posits that political elites play a significant role in shaping public opinion by providing "cues" or signals about how to interpret complex political issues (Friedman, 2012). When elites have a consensus, the public is likely to follow, but when elites disagree, the public's opinions can become polarized. Congressional speeches and hearings act as a platform for elites' cues.

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JANUARY 6 AS A CASE

The events of January 6, 2021, marked a watershed moment in American history when a mob of supporters of then-president Donald Trump stormed the U.S. Capitol. The violent insurrection, fueled by false claims of widespread election fraud and the refusal to accept the outcome of the 2020 presidential election, shocked the nation and reverberated globally. The unprecedented breach of the Capitol highlighted the deep divisions within American society and raised questions about the state of democracy and the role of political leaders in shaping public discourse.

The subsequent establishment of the United States House Select Committee to Investigate the January 6 Attack presents a compelling case study for understanding how politicians discuss false information in the aftermath of a significant and contentious event. The committee's mandate was to examine the circumstances surrounding the attack, the security failures that allowed it, and the role played by various actors, including political leaders, in instigating or responding to the violence. This committee's hearings stand out as a case for studying discourse on false information for several reasons. First, the attack itself was fueled by false narratives and baseless claims of election fraud. The hearings, therefore, became a forum to address and confront the consequences of these falsehoods, making it a valuable case for understanding how political elites grapple with false information that directly contributed to a violent assault on democratic institutions.

Second, the hearings took place in a charged political atmosphere, with deep partisan divides over the legitimacy of the election results. The study of false information in this context becomes particularly relevant as it allows an exploration of how politicians navigate and contribute to the perpetuation of false information within a polarized political landscape. Finally, the hearings present an opportunity to observe how political leaders attribute blame and responsibility for the events of January 6. Understanding the framing of false information in the context of assigning accountability provides insights into the strategic communication employed by politicians to shape public perception and control the narrative surrounding a crisis.

The aftermath of January 6 also saw increased scrutiny of the role of social media platforms in disseminating false information and facilitating the organization of the attack (Ng et al., 2022; Timberg et al., 2021). This raises questions about the complicity or responsibility of political leaders in either countering or amplifying false information through these platforms. The committee hearings

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provide a platform to examine how politicians address the intersection of technology, false information, and the potential impact on democratic processes.

METHODS

I used computational text analysis to extract insights derived from the C-SPAN Video Library to explore how politicians talk about false information. I transcribed the ten public hearings of the United States House Select Committee on the January 6 Attack. I turned the transcripts into a dataset where each observation, or row, represents when a new person speaks or talks in a prerecorded video. I then employed a coding scheme to distinguish between speeches, evidence, and testimonies.

I conducted a three-step computational text analysis to extract meaningful insights from the dataset. The methods used were most frequent word analysis, topic modeling, and sentiment analysis. Most frequent word analysis is used to identify prevalent language and terms used in the hearing, providing insights into the key themes and concepts within the discourse (Dehghani et al., 2017). Topic modeling, specifically latent Dirichlet allocation (LDA), is employed to uncover latent themes and patterns within the dataset, allowing for the identification of prevalent themes without prior assumptions (Marciniak, 2016). Sentiment analysis is used to gauge the overall attitude or tone across the hearings, with a focus on the emotional tone expressed in the text (Wang & Wu, 2013).

The analysis of political framing through computational text analysis has been a subject of interest in various academic works (Diesner, 2015), including through automated frame analysis to understand the narrative surrounding Europe's 2015 refugee crisis (Greussing & Boomgaarden, 2017) and measuring polarization in elite communication during the COVID-19 pandemic (Green et al., 2020). Incorporating sentiment analysis within framing theory helps us to understand how language and emotional tone influence the framing of political discourse as sentiment analysis provides insights into the emotional dimensions of framing, contributing to a comprehensive understanding of how political messages are constructed and perceived.

To analyze the hearings, I first cleaned the data. I combined words that only make sense together. This included "january 6th," "white house," "united states," "vice president," and "thank you." I also made all versions of the United States (e.g., U.S., USA) equivalent. I then removed all punctuation and the standard English

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stop words from the dataset and some additional words that did not add to the context. These included Mr., like, would, one, told, said, think, could, also, know, say, Donald, going, back, get, well, that's, thank, go, day, time, call, see, don't, yes. I then tokenized the data, splitting the sentences into fragments the algorithm can understand. To get the sentiment of each observation, I used the Sentiment Intensity Analyzer from the NLTK package in Python.

Most frequent word analysis involves identifying and totaling the occurrence of words within a dataset to discern patterns and highlight frequently used terms (Laver et al., 2003). This computational text analysis method is particularly useful for uncovering the prevailing language and central concepts within a body of text. Identifying the words that appear most frequently can provide insights into the key themes, concerns, or topics within the discourse. This provides a data-driven understanding of the language employed by political elites. Moreover, the most frequent word analysis serves as an initial step in unraveling the semantic structure of the text, which can help with further, more in-depth examinations of context, sentiment, and nuance.

Topic modeling uncovers latent themes and patterns within the dataset (Marciniak, 2016). To help us understand how politicians discuss false information during the January 6 hearings, topic modeling works by identifying clusters of words that frequently co-occur. I use an LDA, which is a probabilistic model commonly used in natural language processing to analyze large collections of text data (Yang & Zhang, 2018). The algorithm allocates words into topics, allowing the researcher to discern prevalent themes without prior assumptions. Selecting the optimal number of topics in an LDA model is a crucial aspect of the analysis, impacting the interpretability of the results. In this study, the number of topics was determined by a pragmatic approach rooted in the observed data characteristics. The process involved iteratively experimenting with different numbers of topics and evaluating the output based on interpretability and the presence of overlap. A key consideration was to strike a balance between granularity and coherence. After I tested multiple configurations, my choice to settle on three topics was motivated by my observation that increasing the number of topics led to overlap, hindering a clear distinguishing factor among the themes. Selecting three topics was deemed optimal for providing meaningful insights into the thematic structure of political discourse during the January 6 hearings, facilitating a more straightforward interpretation of the results.

Sentiment analysis is my final computational approach as it discerns the emotional tone or attitude expressed in text. This process involves using natural

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language processing algorithms to analyze words and phrases within the text and determine whether they convey positive, negative, or neutral sentiments. The model reflects the overall sentiment expressed in each observation by assigning a numerical score to each analyzed text unit.

RESULTS

Analysis of the January 6 hearings reveals a dynamic interplay between words, topics, and sentiments that depict the narrative. Figure 6.1 provides a visual representation of the most frequently used words, showcasing the prominence of terms like "president," "trump," "election," "capitol," and "people." This underscores the hearings' central focus on blaming President Trump and discussing the consequences of the January 6 events. The subsequent topic model identifies three main themes: (1) the actions of President Trump and the White House; (2) President Trump's claims of election fraud; and (3) the impact on specific people. Each topic is characterized by distinct keywords, offering an overview of the hearings' narrative.

Moving to sentiment analysis, Figure 6.2 unveils the overall sentiment distribution, with a notable prevalence of neutral tones. Surprisingly, negative

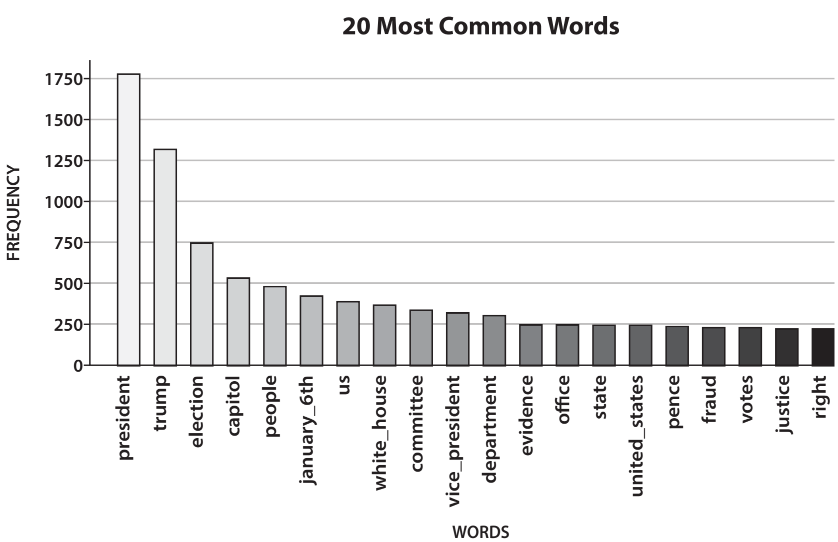

FIGURE 6.1 Top 20 most common words in the January 6 hearings.

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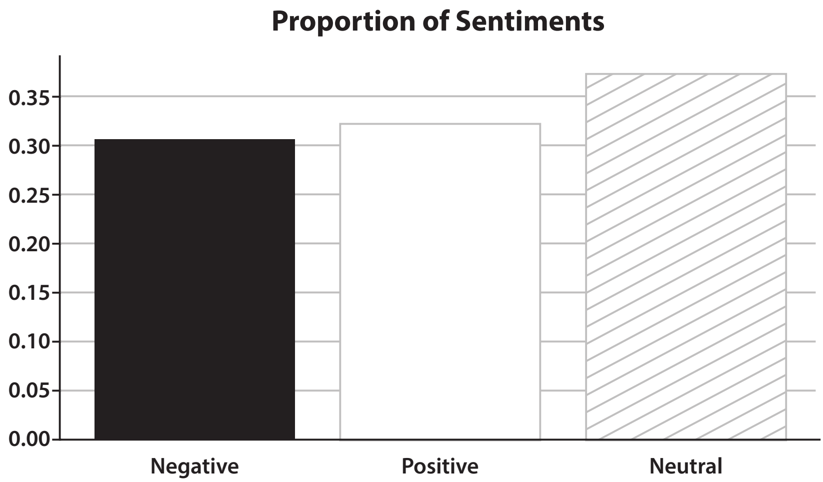

FIGURE 6.2 Proportion of negative, positive, and neutral sentiment across the entire dataset.

sentiment constitutes the smallest proportion, challenging expectations given the context and mission of the hearings. However, a deeper exploration of sentiment reveals intriguing patterns across different speech types and topics. The prevalence of neutral sentiment prompts speculation on the hearings' overall tone. One could hypothesize that while addressing a critical and contentious event, the hearings adopt impartial language to maintain objectivity, reflecting a strategic choice by committee members to navigate the polarized political landscape. Alternatively, it might indicate an effort to present the hearings as a fact-finding mission, emphasizing the pursuit of truth over emotive rhetoric.

Focusing on evidence from the hearings, Figure 6.3 shows a predominantly positive sentiment. This positivity could be attributed to the nature of the evidence, often comprising phone calls between President Trump and his inner circle justifying their actions and portraying their supporters positively. Noteworthy terms in evidence, as illustrated in Figure 6.4, include words like "need" and "right," reflecting a tone of justification and support. The positive sentiment observed in evidence could be strategically employed to present a cohesive narrative from the perspective of those involved, aiming to justify their actions and decisions. It is likely a strategic choice to provide evidence that frames the actors as seeing their actions as okay and showing the committee in a favorable light to highlight why action was needed, casting a positive light on their inquiries. This still raises questions about the rhetorical strategies employed during

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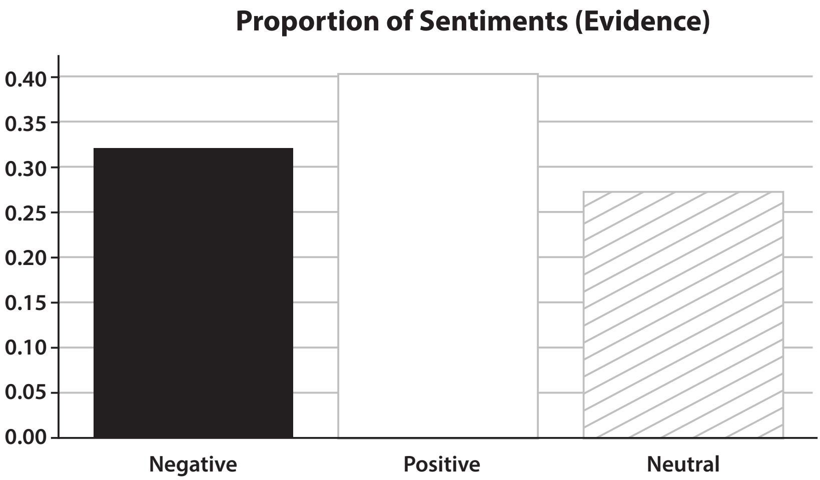

FIGURE 6.3 Proportion of negative, positive, and neutral sentiment across the observations that were evidence.

the hearings and how the presentation of evidence can influence the overall tone of the proceedings.

In contrast, as depicted in Figure 6.5, speeches exhibit a more neutral and slightly negative sentiment. Prepared remarks adopting a legalistic tone may contribute to this negativity, as speeches are likely to emphasize the severity of the

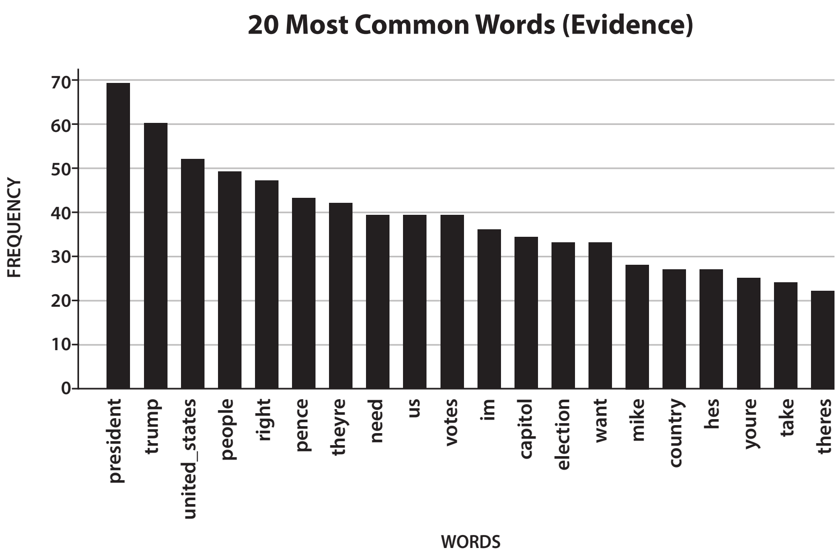

FIGURE 6.4 Most frequent words across the observations that were evidence.

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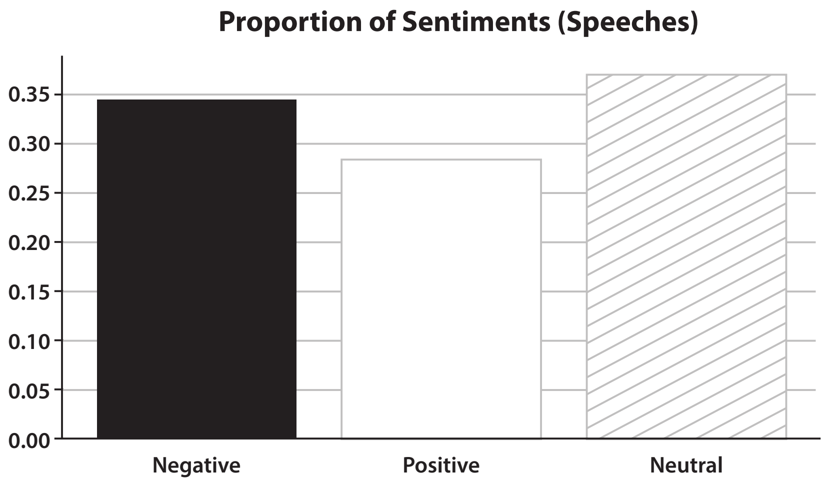

FIGURE 6.5 Proportion of negative, positive, and neutral sentiment across the observations that were speeches.

issue and the reasons for the hearings. Committee members may have opted for neutrality to avoid accusations of partisanship in a politically charged environment. The most common words in speeches, shown in Figure 6.6, highlight a focus on attributing blame, featuring terms like "trump," "president," and "election."

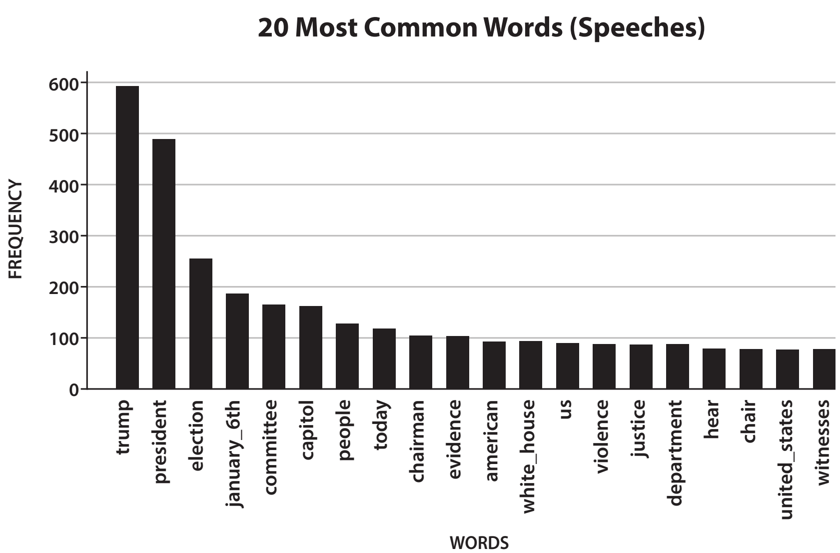

FIGURE 6.6 Most frequent words across the observations that were speeches.

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Legalistic language often employed in prepared remarks tends to lean toward formality and objectivity, which may contribute to a more negative sentiment. Alternatively, the slight negativity could reflect the challenging task of framing the hearings as a bipartisan effort to uncover the truth, balancing the need for a thorough investigation with the political realities of a divided audience.

Testimonies, illustrated in Figure 6.7, strike a predominantly neutral tone, with a slight inclination toward positivity. The legal setting and the presence of lawyers contribute to a more measured and consoling tone. Common words in testimonies, as shown in Figure 6.8, revolve around blame attribution ("President," "Trump") and broader consequences ("Capitol," "People," "White House"). This could be a strategic response to the gravity of the January 6 events and the need to address the public's concerns. Testimonies, a more formal and structured aspect of the hearings, likely aim to project a sense of authority, reliability, and empathy. The neutrality in tone may be a deliberate effort to avoid inflaming emotions or being perceived as biased, especially considering the sensitive nature of the events under scrutiny. The slight positivity could reflect the committee's acknowledgment and appreciation for those willing to testify, potentially aimed at fostering cooperation and maintaining a constructive atmosphere during the hearings. It may also serve as a subtle reassurance to the public that the proceedings are conducted with a commitment to fairness and justice.

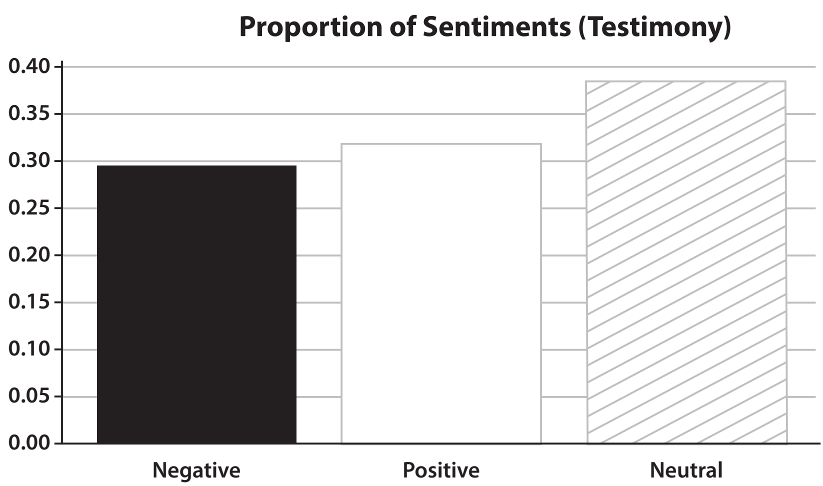

FIGURE 6.7 Proportion of negative, positive, and neutral sentiment across the observations that were testimony.

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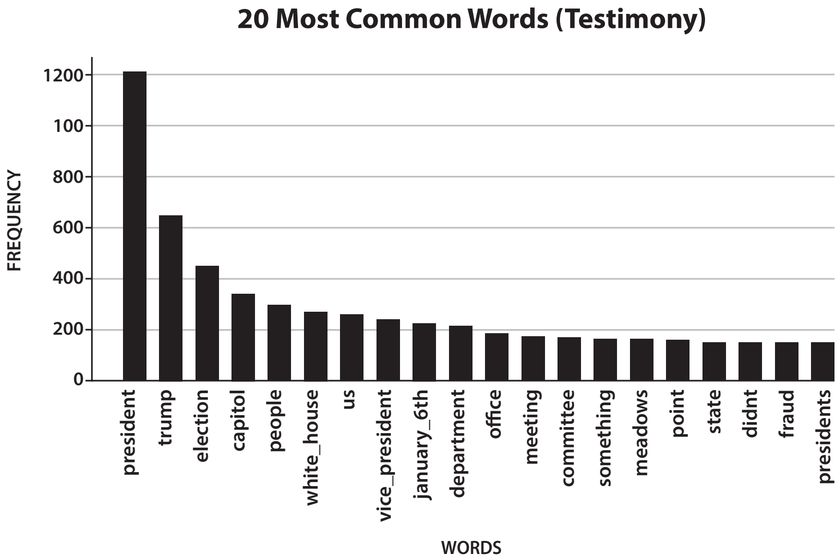

FIGURE 6.8 Most frequent words across the observations that were testimony.

DISCUSSION

The analysis of the January 6 hearings reveals a complex interplay between words, topics, and sentiments, which is indicative of the framing literature and understanding the construction of political narratives (Matthes, 2012). The most frequently used words, such as "President," "Trump," "Election," "Capitol," and "People," underscore the central focus on blaming President Trump and discussing the consequences of the January 6 events. The results of this study shed light on the nuanced dynamics of sentiment, topics, and speech types within the January 6 hearings, offering valuable insights into how politicians frame and discuss false information, thereby potentially influencing public opinion via agenda-setting (Walgrave et al., 2018). The initial impression of more positive sentiment is nuanced upon closer examination, revealing an overarching tendency toward neutrality, potentially influenced by the formal and legal tone set by the hearings. This observation prompts questions about the potential consequences of this neutrality, such as signaling to the public that false information may not be as significant a problem as anticipated (Friedman, 2012).

There is also the possibility that the tone of the hearings caused the general public to lose interest. Leading up to the hearings, there was a lot of talk about

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what would happen in the hearings. However, there was limited reporting following them. The story that gained the most media traction was the video of Nancy Pelosi and others hiding in the Capitol, as it was more sensationalist. If the committee's goal is to get people to pay attention and realize the problems with false information, is it a disservice to not use a more salacious negative tone when discussing it?

Overall, the tone is neutral with a predominant focus on the attribution of blame and a secondary focus on the impact. But for the impact on people, the sentiment is positive, as if the committee members are trying to console them. By subgroup, the evidence is much more positive, as those involved in the January 6 attack try to preemptively justify their actions.

This research serves as a starting point to provide insights into how politicians frame and discuss false information. Future research could use video analysis to capture more subtle differences in how legislators talk about false information—for example, capturing facial expressions or body language. It would also be useful to compare the framing of this hearing to other hearings and political events, particularly since that would provide more variety in partisanship. It would also be interesting to compare to see how the discourse has changed over time or context.

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